Erdong Xu

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Education

The George Washington University 2020–2026
Ph.D. in Economics

Tufts University 2018–2020
M.S. in Economics

Xiamen University
B.A. in Economics 2013–2017
B.A. in Philosophy 2015–2017

Research Fields

Political Economy; Economic History; Applied Microeconomics; Development Economics

Research

Printing Morality: *Uncle Tom's Cabin* and the Antebellum Political Realignment Job Market Paper

This paper examines how a widely circulated cultural narrative contributed to electoral realignment. I combine historical newspaper advertisements with transportation networks to construct county-level exposure to *Uncle Tom's Cabin*. Difference-in-differences estimates for northern counties without recorded advertisements show larger declines in Democratic support and increases in Republican support in more exposed counties, particularly in 1856. A one-standard-deviation difference in log exposure corresponds to a 2.7-percentage-point larger decline in Democratic presidential vote share, with similar patterns in congressional elections. Household naming choices, newspaper discussions, and contemporary political references document the novel's broader cultural reception and political use. The findings suggest that cultural diffusion can help make moral arguments consequential for electoral outcomes.

Delegating Enforcement: Evidence from U.S. Immigration Policing Working Paper

How does delegating federal authority to local police expand enforcement? Using the Trump administration's 2025 expansion of the 287(g) Task Force Model and newly released ICE arrest records, I employ a stacked difference-in-differences design to estimate the additional enforcement generated by local deputization. Adoption increases total ICE arrests by approximately 20 percent, and the increase extends to people with neither recorded convictions nor pending charges. Further evidence indicates larger effects in areas with greater preexisting federal detention activity. The findings identify the allocation of legal authority as an important margin of state capacity and suggest complementarities between local implementation and federal infrastructure.

Tariff Interests and Political Realignment after the Panic of 1857 Working Paper

This paper examines how a financial crisis activated preexisting economic interests. Combining manufacturing structure with tariff rates, I show that counties with stronger pre-Panic tariff interests experienced larger declines in Democratic support and greater movement toward the Republican coalition after 1857. Congressional tariff votes also indicate increased support for protectionist legislation. The findings connect economic distress, demands for protection, and partisan realignment.

Redirecting Southwest China's Seaward Trade: Evidence from the Pinglu Canal Work in Progress

This project studies how the newly opened Pinglu Canal changes market access and connects inland economies to maritime trade. I am assembling geographic and economic data to examine how improved connectivity generates and reallocates economic activity across ports and hinterland regions, with implications for public investment and regional development.

Experience

Instructor, The George Washington University 2024
Principles of Mathematics for Economics

Research Assistant, The George Washington University 2021–2023
Advisor: Prof. Maggie X. Chen

Teaching Assistant, The George Washington University 2022–2023
International Economics; Principles of Mathematics for Economics

Instructor, Osher Lifelong Learning Institute, Tufts University 2020
Introduction to Chinese Philosophy

Instructor, Osher Lifelong Learning Institute, Tufts University 2019
A Brief Introduction to Shenzhen: 1978–2018

Conferences and Presentations

AEA/ASSA Annual Meeting (Poster; accepted)	Washington, DC, 2027
International Conference on Empirical Political Economy	Xiamen, 2026
XMU Workshop on History, Institutions, and Economic Development	Xiamen, 2026
ASREC Annual Meeting	Los Angeles, 2026
Washington Area International Trade Symposium (Poster)	Washington, DC, 2026
World Economic History Congress	Lund, 2025
Economic History Association Annual Meeting (Poster)	Pittsburgh, 2023
ACES Political Economy Summer School	San Francisco, 2023
Warwick CAGE PhD Summer School	Coventry, 2023

Skills

Software: Python, Stata, QGIS
Languages: English (fluent), Chinese (native)

References

Maggie X. Chen
Professor of Economics, The George Washington University
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Alessandra Fenizia
Assistant Professor of Economics, The George Washington University
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Yingyan Zhao
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